now increased to 10." Some time ago, Jaju's firm, following up on a lead from a data leak investigation, took up a screening exercise with an Indian IT outsourcer and found that some employees were simultaneously working for another competitor. Their method of probe included digital forensics, social network analytics, scanning CVs, emails and Provident Fund data for multiple accounts.

In July, Kotak Institutional Equities polled about 400 employees in the IT and IT-enabled services sector to gauge their intent to return to the workplace. According to the report, a staggering 65 per cent of the respondents highlighted that they knew of people pursuing part-time opportunities/moonlighting while working from home. "If you are skilled, it's huge money," says a manager at a Bengaluru-based tech company. Another IT hand concurs: "The guys who moonlight are the ones who are really good at their job."

A CASE FOR FREELANCING

An offshore gig, say from the US, can fetch $15-100 an hour depending on one's talent, says a 29-year-old product developer at a start-up. "So it becomes lucrative." Plus, for someone with plans for a start-up somewhere along the line, there's the added benefit of learning how businesses work. "You get the exposure that you will not get in an MNC." However, side hustles aren't for everyone, argues another software developer. "It's more difficult to be your own self-made freelancing kind of guy." There are several avenues to land a part-time job. Siva Prasad Nanduri, chief business officer, IT Staffing, TeamLease, says there are multiple platforms where people can pick up a piece of a project. "It is pretty common in the US and Europe."

For companies trying to counter this by bringing back employees to the office, it hasn't been an easy transition. Currently, only about 30 per cent of the IT workforce is back at offices, according to industry experts. Since Covid-time restrictions lifted, firms have been nudging employees to return, but there has been resistance. Hence, many employers are trying to enforce a mid-way solution—three days a week in the office, at least. A senior manager at a small-sized IT services firm in Bengaluru says his company is offering remote work options to new employees only after they have completed six months of working from the office. The general preference among employees, however, is for remote, or hybrid work. "We speak to about 10,000 IT job-seekers every day and 60 per cent of them say they want a remote job," says Kamal Karanth, co-founder at specialist staffing firm Xpheno. "If nothing is available, then they say hybrid is okay." With attrition levels still high, employers are wary of ordering an outright shift back to the cubicle. Demand for certain IT roles is still high. "If you are a full-stack developer (with expertise in both frontend and backend), you will get at least 10-12 calls a day even now," says Karanth.

WHY PEOPLE MOONLIGHT

EXTRA MONEY: Techies say side gigs can fetch anywhere between $15 and $100 an hour depending on talent

WORK FROM HOME: Freelancing during off-work hours isn't new. But pandemic-time remote working saw a rise in people taking up side hustles

DEMAND: The tech shift during the pandemic has created a huge demand for skills

START-UP AMBITIONS: Most tech start-up folk, invariably, have juggled personal projects with a regular job

HOW RAMPANT IS IT?

ACCORDING TO A JULY REPORT by Kotak Institutional Equities, of about 400 employees in the IT and IT-enabled services sector surveyed, 65 per cent said that they knew of people pursuing part-time opportunities /moonlighting while working from home

THE FUTURE IS FLEXI

The debate, therefore, appears to be enmeshed in the larger context of a changed work environment on the one side, and the infringement of an exclusive employment contract on the other. "The reality is that there are people today working for Wipro and working directly for one of our competitors. And we'd actually discovered 300 people in the past few months who were doing exactly that. To me, that's a complete violation of integrity in its deepest form," Rishad Premji had said at an All India Management Association event on September 21. That wasn't the first time the Wipro executive chairman had spoken about moonlighting. In a tweet in August, he had called it 'cheating, plain and simple'. Sharing that view was IBM India's managing director Sandip Patel. But there were other points of view, notably from Tech Mahindra CEO C.P. Gurnani who didn't think moonlighting was rampant. "There will always be a few cases," Gurnani said in August. "If someone is meeting the efficiency and productivity norms and he wants to make some extra money as long as he is not committing fraud, he is